session of the 7th Central Committee meeting that there should be no rush to secure independent recognition immediately, or even for a considerable period after the final victory. [17] After the Communists overran Nanking (Nanjing), the capital city of the Nationalist government, on 23 April 1949, they first de-recognized all the foreign envoys based in China, and declared them to be ordinary foreigners with no special privileges. [18] Subsequently, they laid down precise conditions for countries wishing to establish diplomatic relations with the new regime, through the interim Constitution, known as the 'Common Programme', which the New Chinese People's Political Consultative Committee had adopted in mid-1949. The Common Programme stipulated that the Chinese central government would negotiate with any foreign government that was willing to sever all relations with the KMT and was ready to adopt a friendly attitude towards the PRC, provided that such relations would be established on the basis of equality, mutual benefit and mutual respect for territorial sovereignty. These conditions were reiterated in a subsequent official communication that was sent to foreign governments after the People's Republic of China was established on 1 October 1949. [19]

Thus the Communists made it mandatory for any country wishing to have diplomatic relations with the new government in Beijing, to withdraw all recognition from the Chiang Kai-shek regime; it was to be either full recognition of the People's Republic of China or nothing. In this way, the new rulers of China laid down their 'red lines' on the issue of diplomatic relations. Mao Zedong summed up his approach by telling Soviet dictator Josef Stalin on 16 December 1949: '. . . we believe that we should not rush to be recognized. We must first bring order to the country, strengthen our position and then we can talk to foreign imperialists.' [20] It was a methodical approach.